



Horsepower or megahertz

In today's age of smartphones, OS manufacturers are competing to take over your car's dashboard. Continue reading: <http://dgit.in/MegaHorse>



China's Titanic replica

China is reportedly building a \$160 million full-sized replica theme park of the Titanic at the banks of the Qijiang River. <http://dgit.in/Ctitanic>

GEEK-KEY



We weren't kidding, she's literally sitting there

CAT MEMES - ORIGINS

The obsession with cats, unfortunately, is hard to find a definite root for. Perhaps in the distant future, historians of culture will have embraced technology enough to be able to webcrawl through the sludge of archived webpages to find the first true 'cat meme' that was more than just a picture of a cat. Today, however, we're restricted to heuristics and macroscopic trends. What we do know is that pictures of cats used to be shared as far back as the primordial 'Usenet'.

Cat photos and simple, quirky, interesting ideas and thoughts about them, soon began to spread on other pre-YouTube forums like FARK, Metafilter, and B3TA Forum. Kitten-related chain emails like the popular forward, 'Every time you masturbate, God kills a kitten' began to gain traction in the late 90s.

LOLCATS: MILLENNIAL MEME RUSH

LOLcats (photos of cats with silly captions, the true origins of the 'white-text-on-image' format of the modern meme) and Caturday (the tradition of posting cat-related images on Saturdays) continued to propagate in their own niches on 4chan and Something Awful for the first few years of the new millennium. The rise of YouTube (created in 2005) however, changed everything. LOLcats truly became the apple of the Internet's eye by 2007, with the rise of *I Can Has Cheezburger*. And the ball has never stopped rolling.

THE BIG QUESTION: WHY?

Cat-related content usually becomes popular for being one of two things – funny or cute. This is confirmed by several surprisingly detailed studies,

(<http://dgit.in/sciofcute>) and by what this writer tells himself at 9 am when aforementioned furball begins her incessant whining. In fact, the writer is of the personal opinion that these qualities of funniness and cuteness form the entirety of the positive contribution cats make to planet Earth, with only diminishing returns as they grow older.

But what sets funny or cute apart from say, poignant, shocking, or violent? And secondly, what about cats makes them so particularly relatable in these funny and cute memes? Why are cats the funniest, cutest animals on the internet?

The answer to the first question lies perhaps in a sort of universal balance, a yin and yang law of the Internet. It should come as no surprise that the internet was, is and will continue to be a pretty dark place. The Dark Web, where drugs are dealt, weapons are exchanged, passwords are sold and depravity is traded, might be one extreme of the internet's closeted skeletons, but there are milder yet equally dark hints of them all over the place. Looking at you 4chan. In fact this dark side has been present from the early stages of internet culture, about two decades ago.

It can be imagined, then, that a sort of public acknowledgement of one's own humanity could be seen in the simple cuteness of kittens playing with a finger, or tasting a lemon for the first time. It's the simple reductionist thought of 'Hey, I guess there's something normal about me after all - even with all of this messed up stuff that I keep browsing all day, I'm able to sit back and enjoy a kitten video.' It's a played down sort of version of Vito Corleone's deadly appetite for murder, contrasted with his ability to have a beautiful family moment. And if we know one thing, it is that internet users loooove to feel cooler than they actually are.

All in all, cute, silly, funny content – essentially what memes are, even at their darkest – help keep the internet a

light-hearted, happy place.

The second question is perhaps slightly harder to answer. Why cats? What makes cats so integral to the 'cute and funny' needs of the internet? Some markedly un-Freudian psychoanalysis comes of use here – cats are, by far, the most human creatures (screw you apes!). This is not by virtue of their intelligence, rather, a product of their imperfections. Cats are a-holes. They whine when they want something and later forget that they owe you a favour. They throw tantrums, and are unpredictable, and they pretty much only show affection when they need something. In fact, cats are disturbingly familiar because they're just like people. Teenagers to be precise.

Perhaps it would help to contrast cats with other animals. Dogs, are far too naive, far too trusting, far too open with their love. It becomes hard for human beings to truly empathise with dogs, to see themselves in them, especially on the mass scale that the internet provides. And honestly, what other competition is there? Sloths, those daft creatures, enjoy a niche audience for memes, yet they are far from the mainstream – a fact possibly attributable to the typical sloth aficionado's deathly laziness.

Cats alone hold a simple, less evil, yet still evil version of ourselves up for our scrutiny. In this mirror we can every trace our own journey – having started out small, harmless, perhaps even adorable, we grow into the very monsters we once feared, and learn not to beat ourselves up about it. After all, both cats and humans are non-ideal beings in a non-ideal world. And it touches us to see that they too can be innocent, silly, funny, cute.

Cats remind us of our imperfections, of our helplessness, of our absolute inability to maintain a good mood when being woken up.

In embracing cats, we embrace ourselves, as flawed, mean, selfish human beings. Yeah, that's the key takeaway for today. Meanwhile, a certain someone needs to relieve herself, and the writer's trousers are, for completely unrelated reasons, being ripped to shreds. 